become the possession of you foreign *sahibs*.'
This *Lat* [Lord – that is, Macnaghten] – that wise and wily man –
When he heard these words

Became excited and said:
'O Shah! May your fortune be blessed!

If it suits you thus
Get your things in order for heading to Kabul

My only fear is this: that the people there
Might find the taste of my sherbet bitter.

But now is the time to set to the chase
When will you ever have such a hunt again?'[122]

The reality seems to have been slightly different. Macnaghten was impressed by the sexagenarian's dignity and 'much struck with the majestic appearance of the old pretender, especially with the flowing honours of a black beard descending to his waist . . . patiently awaiting the *kismet*, or fate, which was to restore him to his throne'.[123] But he was in no mood to be further delayed in implementing his plans by the sensitivities of Sadozais, who were hardly in a position to strike a bargain in the way the Sikhs had. Shuja was curtly informed of the plans, and of the boundaries of the somewhat diminished and truncated Afghanistan he was going to be allowed to rule. He received some assurances about the British not interfering with his family or in his internal affairs without his royal approval, and about being given financial assistance for reconstructing Afghanistan and consolidating his rule after the conquest. Given his long-standing problems with runaway slave girls in Ludhiana, according to his own account of the negotiations Shuja asked for a clause in the treaty guaranteeing that 'The maid-servants who run away from one land to another shall be exchanged and given back. It is impossible that a King can have honour and pride without maid-servants.'[124] He was also assured he would be allowed to enter Afghanistan at the head of his own troops, using the same route as he had done in 1833–4, and not merely be placed on the throne trailing behind British regiments. Finally, he was also promised additional funds which he could use to train up his own forces as he had done on the previous campaign.